It reminded me of something that James Madison said in 1788: “Since the general civilization of mankind, I believe there are more instances of the abridgement of the freedom of the people by gradual and silent encroachment of those in power than by violent and sudden usurpations.”

His friend and neighbor, Thomas Jefferson, thought much the same way. “What has destroyed liberty and the rights of men in every government that has ever existed under the sun?” he asked, and then gave an answer: “The generalizing and concentrating of all cares and powers into one body.”

As governor, I’d experienced how the federal bureaucracy had its hand in everything and was “concentrating all cares and power into one body.” Washington would establish a new program that the states were supposed to administer, then set so many rules and regulations that the state wasn’t really administering it—you were just following orders from Washington. Most of these programs could not only be operated more effectively but more economically under our own laws.

The federal government hadn’t created the states; the states had created the federal government. Washington, ignoring principles of the Constitution, was trying to turn the states into nothing more than administrative districts of the federal government. And the path to federal control had, to a large extent, become federal aid. From our schools to our farms, Washington bureaucrats were trying to dictate to Americans what they could or could not do, and were portraying bureaucratic control as the price Americans must pay for federal aid administered from Washington. The money came with strings that reached all the way back to the Potomac.

Usually with the best of intentions, Congress passed a new program, appropriated the money for it, then assigned bureaucrats in Washington to disperse the money; almost